

Alpha Blockers (for Prostate and Urine Flow)

Patient Information · Pills that relax the bladder outlet to improve urine flow

WARWIKI

Alpha blockers are pills that **relax the muscle** in the prostate and at the bladder outlet. This makes it easier to urinate. They are a common first medicine for urine symptoms from an **enlarged prostate (BPH)**. Common ones are **tamsulosin (Flomax)**, **alfuzosin**, **silodosin**, **doxazosin** and **terazosin**. They work fairly quickly but do not shrink the prostate.

How It Works

An enlarged prostate squeezes the urine channel. Alpha blockers **relax the muscle at the bladder outlet**. This gives a stronger stream, with less trouble starting, less straining and less stop-and-start flow. They treat the **symptoms** only. They do not change the size of the prostate, so the benefit lasts only while you take them.

What to Expect

- Many men feel better **within days**. The full effect can take a few weeks.
- Most are taken **once a day**. Tamsulosin is taken about **30 minutes after the same meal** each day. Silodosin and alfuzosin are taken with a meal.
- Doxazosin and terazosin are started at a low dose and raised slowly to limit dizziness. Terazosin is started **at bedtime**.
- For a large prostate, they can be combined with a medicine that shrinks the prostate.

Learn the Terms

Alpha blocker

A pill that relaxes the muscle at the bladder outlet.

BPH

Benign prostatic hyperplasia. An enlarged prostate that is not cancer.

Bladder neck

The muscle ring where the bladder joins the urethra.

Orthostatic hypotension

Dizziness when you stand up, from a drop in blood pressure.

IFIS

"Floppy iris." An eye problem that can happen during cataract surgery.

Priapism

An erection that will not go down. It is rare but urgent.

Planning cataract surgery? Tell your eye surgeon if you take an alpha blocker **or have ever taken one**. It can make the iris “floppy” during surgery (IFIS). The risk can last up to a year after you stop, so stopping first does not remove it. If you need both, cataract surgery before starting the pill is often best.

How to Take It

- Take it **at the same time each day**, as directed.
- Do not double up if you miss a dose.
- If you stop for several days, ask your team before restarting. You may need to restart at a lower dose.
- Tell your team about all your medicines. Some antibiotics and antifungal pills do not mix with these.
- Before starting tamsulosin, tell your team if you have ever had a serious allergy to a sulfa drug.

Important Safety

- Stand up **slowly**, especially at first, to avoid dizziness, falls or fainting.
- Take care with **erection pills** or blood pressure medicines. Together they can add to dizziness.
- **Less or no semen** is common with tamsulosin and silodosin. It is not harmful. If it bothers you, or you are trying to have a child, tell your team. A different medicine may help.

Common Side Effects

- Dizziness or lightheadedness, and tiredness
- Stuffy nose
- Less or no semen

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Dizziness that keeps happening, or a fall
- Urine symptoms that are not getting better

Go to an emergency department if:

- You faint, or have chest pain
- You cannot urinate and your bladder feels full or painful
- An erection lasts more than **4 hours**
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Alpha blockers ease urine flow but do not shrink the prostate.
2. Stand up slowly, especially in the first weeks.
3. Tell your eye surgeon about any past or current use before cataract surgery.